

MP-IMG-003 Shoulder MRI

1 Purpose and scope

This policy describes when Meridian Health Plan considers MRI of the shoulder without contrast medically necessary. It applies to CPT code 73221. Meridian Health Plan is a fictional payer created for a portfolio project, and this document is not clinical guidance.

2 Definitions

Conservative therapy for the shoulder means at least 6 weeks of treatment that combines two or more of the following: supervised physical therapy, anti-inflammatory or analgesic medication, activity modification, and a subacromial or glenohumeral injection. Rotator cuff weakness means reduced strength on abduction or external rotation, or a positive drop-arm test or empty can (Jobe) test.

3.1 Suspected rotator cuff tear

Shoulder MRI is approved for a suspected rotator cuff tear when the examination shows rotator cuff weakness and pain persists after at least 6 weeks of conservative therapy. No trial of conservative therapy is required after acute traumatic onset when the patient cannot actively abduct the arm.

3.2 Labral tear or shoulder instability

Shoulder MRI is approved for a suspected labral tear when the patient has recurrent dislocation or subluxation, a positive apprehension test, or persistent pain or instability after a traumatic dislocation, and radiographs have been reviewed.

3.3 Adhesive capsulitis

MRI is not medically necessary to diagnose adhesive capsulitis (frozen shoulder), which is a clinical diagnosis based on limited active and passive range of motion. MRI may be approved when the examination also suggests a rotator cuff tear or when surgery is planned.

4 Exclusions

Shoulder MRI is not considered medically necessary in these situations:

- routine screening or imaging without documented examination findings
- shoulder pain of less than 6 weeks duration without trauma or weakness
- a repeat MRI within 12 months without a change in clinical status

5 Required documentation

The request must include laterality (right or left); range of motion and strength findings; results of special tests; the radiograph result; each conservative treatment tried, with dates, duration and response; the mechanism of injury if traumatic; and the CPT and ICD-10 codes.